



A GREY WINTER IN MANCHESTER

Both Manchester clubs go into the new year needing some **soul-searching** as they desperately to salvage their campaigns.

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An inexcusable loss to Manchester United was not the end of a nightmare run for Pep Guardiola and Manchester City. In its following league game, Aston Villa's Morgan Rogers ran riot against City, casting a dark and gloomy shadow of doubt over whether Guardiola's reign on English soil had run its course.

The doubts escalated further when relegation-threatened Everton held City 1-1 on Boxing Day, with Erling Haaland draining any remaining Christmas cheer after missing from the spot (**above**).



"Life is not easy. Sport is not easy," Guardiola said after the match.

Over the last few years, City has been known for losing the odd game here and there during the season, but one win in 13 games is inconceivable. Now, even an unbeaten run similar to those seen in the recent past might not be enough to catch high-flying Liverpool at the top of the table.

However, Guardiola's record-breaking feats with the club are enough to ward off any suggestions of a sacking, especially with half the season remaining.